

致家长的一封信 · A Letter to Parents

DIGITAL LEARNING ·

A TWO-SEMESTER PUBLIC COURSE

致家长的一封信

A Letter to Parents

· About the Digital Learning course

Date Fill in date of this letter

尊敬的家长：

Dear Parents,

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I am your child’s mentor in Digital Learning. Let me begin with something honest: entrusting your child to a course with no classroom, no bell, and nobody standing over their shoulder takes trust. This letter is written for that trust. I want you to know exactly where this course is taking your child, what they will do each week, how we protect them, and — concretely — how you can help over the year ahead.

You do not need to reply to this letter or sign anything. Reading it takes about ten minutes. If you only have three, please turn straight to Section 6 (*How you can help*) and Section 8 (*Three things we ask of you*) — those two sections are what this letter is really for.

一、这是一门什么课，为什么要有它

1. What this course is, and why it exists

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Your child’s generation can find almost any knowledge online. But there is a long distance between *finding* and *learning*. They swipe through videos, switch apps, and coordinate flawlessly inside a game — yet often do not know how to set a learning goal for themselves, how to judge whether a claim is true, or how to finish something when nobody is watching. **They are natives of the digital world, but that does not make them competent learners in it.** These are two entirely different things.

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This course does not teach a piece of software. It teaches **how to learn** — especially how to make learning actually happen online, alone. Semester 1 lays the foundation, “getting equipped, learning to learn”: writing a proper email, taking screenshots and screen recordings, reading English with translation tools, managing accounts and passwords, searching and recording sources, and setting up a personal digital workspace. From there we move to the deeper questions: what learning is, what digital learning is, and how to make learning actually happen. Semester 2 turns to “judging, creating, self-directing”: weighing the credibility of online information, managing one’s digital footprint and wellbeing, agreeing a family media agreement at home, making a micro-lesson for next year’s students, and finally completing an independent capstone project.

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An analogy: this course is a bit like helping a child pack the luggage, the map, and the common sense before a long journey abroad — for many parents the digital world is a foreign country, with its own language and its own customs, full of abundant resources and hidden traps alike. **Where the analogy breaks down:** a foreign country can be skipped, and you can always fly home. The digital world cannot. Your child already lives there; we cannot keep them outside the gate, only raise someone who can take care of themselves inside it and genuinely learn there. And strictly speaking you are not waving goodbye at the border — you are in the same country, having simply arrived later.

二、这门课怎么运行

2. How the course runs

Length	16 each. Two semesters, 16 teaching weeks
Format	— — Fully asynchronous online self-study — no class meetings, no live sessions, no fixed hour at which your child must be somewhere.
Weeks	” ” The course speaks in weeks, not dates; on statutory holidays that week’s work rolls forward, and holiday weeks such as National Day are buffer weeks with no new content.

Weekly time	120 Required work never exceeds 120 minutes a week, external course included; anything marked optional is outside that budget.
Rhythm	Pages open Monday; suggested pace is materials by Wednesday, task by Saturday, publish and log by Sunday.
Late work	” ” There are no late penalties. We give a suggested pace instead, because the next week does not wait. If they fall behind: do the current week first, then catch up in a buffer week.
Individual learning	Designed for the individual learner: no group work, no forum, no peer replies. Every artifact is your child's own, and every week closes with their own reflection.
Mentors	30 The course has two mentors, each supporting about 30 students; I am one of them. Every week I check the progress of every student in my group, score their work by rubric, reply by email, contact any student whose work is missing that same week, and offer 1:1 video by appointment.

One thing must be said plainly: **an online course is not the easy option**. It saves the commute and the seat time, and asks for far more self-management in exchange. The syllabus recommends reserving two roughly one-hour blocks each week for this course. This is precisely where you can help most (Section 6).

三、孩子的一周，具体是什么样

3. *What a week actually looks like*

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Each teaching week is **one web page** — and that page *is* the week's learning, not a doorway to an assignment. It always has the same ten parts:

1. — — **Objectives** — what they should be able to do by the end.
2. — — / 120 **Time estimate** — minutes for watching/reading, for doing, for reflecting, adding up to no more than 120, printed openly on the page.

3. — —

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Materials — text plus a short video (hosted where it opens directly in mainland China, under five minutes, with bilingual captions, and **a full text version alongside every video** so the week works even if the video does not).

4. — —

Follow-along — a small in-browser exercise with instant feedback, ungraded.

5. + + — —

The week's task, its rubric, and a checkable self-review list.

6. — —

Self-quiz — ungraded, retakeable, with instant explanations; it exists only to show them what they have not understood yet.

7. · — —

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Reflection ·

the three-line log — three lines on their own website each week: **what I learned · where I got stuck · what I will do next week.**

8. — —

120

Want more? — optional extras, ungraded, outside

the 120 minutes.

9. — — ”

” **Suggested pace** — for example, “materials by Wednesday,

task by Saturday”.

10. — —

FAQ — the places students most often get stuck,

answered on the page first.

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” ” ” ”

In Week 3 your child builds a personal website on the course's designated builder, with three pages: **About me · Learning log · Portfolio**. From then on that website is their notebook: every piece of work is published there and every week gets its three-line log. Semester 2 adds two more pages, *Project* and *My year*.

“ ” “ ”

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120

During Semester 1 your child also picks two free public online courses from a course menu and actually takes them (one *core* course to finish, one *explore* course sampled for two or three lessons) — **the best way to learn how to learn online is to really learn something online**. The core course runs one hour a week in the later part of the semester, and that hour sits inside the 120 minutes. **Before registering on any external course platform, we ask your child to tell you first.**

四、作品怎么评，放在哪里

4. How work is assessed, and where it lives

Assessment here is not marking right and wrong; it is reading evidence against a standard. Every graded task comes with a rubric whose rows *are* that module's learning objectives, and each row has four levels:

Level	What it means
Meets	The work clearly does what the objective asks.
Developing	On the right track, not there yet.
Not yet	The objective has not been met yet.
No evidence	 Not “poor work” but “nothing to read” — usually a missing step that can simply be added.

“ ”

Please note that last level in particular. “No evidence” is not a judgement of your child’s ability; it says this submission did not show us enough. That is fixable, and often needs no more than one added sentence or one screenshot.

100 60 85 ” ”

Work is **published on your child's own website**, and the link to that page is registered with me. Enrolled students are scored by me against the rubric and receive email feedback within a week. Each semester is out of 100: 60 or above passes and earns the semester certificate, 85 or above is marked "with distinction", and passing both semesters earns the year certificate.

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The course also includes a few **ungraded “learning self-checks”** so your child can compare themselves at the start and end of a semester. They never enter the grade, never affect the certificate, and the results display only in your child’s own browser.

五、隐私与安全：我们做了哪些保护

5. Privacy and safety: what we have put in place

This is what parents ask about most, so let me be as concrete as I can:

- **Pseudonyms, not real names.** Your child uses an English name or a pseudonym on their site.

- **No face photos, no full school name** — and no one else’s personal information, either.
- “ ”
The site is set to no-index by default. In the week they build it, we walk them through switching that off step by step: the site opens by link, but does not appear in search results.
- “ ”
Making the site public is only an option at the very end of the second semester, and only with written parental consent. Until then, going public is simply not an action that exists.
- — — **VPN** **All**
tools are free and sign up with an email address only — no phone number, no VPN. This is a hard rule for tool selection in this course, not a preference.
- **AI** AI 14
 AI **AI use has explicit rules.** Nothing in Semester 1 requires an AI tool; some tools’ terms require guardian consent under 14; and the course rules are firm: AI-generated content may never be submitted as one’s own, factual claims must be verified against a reliable source, and **personal information — your child’s or anyone else’s — is never to be typed into an AI tool.**
- **The**
interactive parts of each page — checkboxes, quizzes, progress bar — require no account at all; progress is stored only in your child’s own browser and is not collected by us.
- “ ”

If the site breaks, content is lost, or your child meets anything online that makes them uncomfortable, please email me immediately. **On matters like these, earlier is always better, and there is no such thing as overreacting.**

六、家长可以怎样帮忙

6. *How you can help*

This section is what the letter is for. Every item below is something you could do this week; none of them is a slogan.

1)

1) **Protect a quiet two hours**

— — “ ” ” ” ” ” ” ”

Together with your child, pick **two roughly one-hour slots** in the week (Wednesday evening and Saturday morning, say), write them into the family calendar, and treat them as a real class. During those two hours: no errands, no visits, no television in the background. Asynchronous courses are most often eaten by the phrase “you can do it anytime” — and

“anytime” tends to become “no time.” Over a semester, the difference between a child whose hours are on the calendar and one who works “when they remember” is very large.

2)

2) Ask about the process; do not audit the answers

Every week your child writes three lines: **what I learned · where I got stuck · what I’ll do next.** Those three lines are the best possible opening for a conversation about learning. Try questions like:

- “ ” — “Where did you get stuck this week, and how did you get around it?”
- “ ” — “What are you going to change about that next week?”
- “ ” — “Which part of what you made this week are you happiest with?”

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Please **avoid**: “Are you done?” “What did you score?” “What did the teacher say you got wrong?” Those three questions turn learning into inspection — and **inspection teaches children to hide, not to ask for help.** Something I have said in earlier parent talks still holds: a conversation is not a parent asking and a child answering; it is two people each saying how they see it. **If there is something to talk about, that is already a good conversation.**

3)

3) When your child is stuck, follow these three steps

” ”

This course treats being stuck as part of learning, and teaches children how to ask for help. What you can do is **walk them through the process, not solve it for them:**

1. — — ”
Have them state the problem — one sentence covering “what I was trying to do, what I did, what happened”, plus a screenshot. Simply writing the problem down clearly solves a fair share of problems outright.
2. — —
24–48 **Have them email me themselves.** Not you sending it, not you drafting it — writing that email is itself part of what Semester 1 teaches. I reply within 24–48 hours (holidays excepted).
3. **While waiting, let them move to the next thing.** A stuck item set aside is not a failure; it is an item in a queue.

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There is one case where you should step in directly: **anything involving safety, privacy, money, or something that has upset your child.** Contact me at once; do not wait for your child to raise it.

4) Resist doing the work for them

This is probably the hardest one. Their audio recording will stumble, their short essay will read thin, their website will look plain — and you could fix all of it in five minutes. Please don't.

A flawed piece your child made themselves is worth far more than a polished piece made for them, because the rubric reads *evidence* — and evidence shows who did the thinking. Nearly every task here is scored on “what you did and why”, not on how handsome the result looks.

What you can absolutely do: sit beside them; be their first audience; be the person they explain it to (“I didn’t follow that step — can you say it again?” — **explaining something once beats re-reading it three times**).

5)

5) Celebrate the process, not the score

Put your praise here: “You tried a different method this time.” “You wrote down where you got stuck.” “You emailed your mentor yourself.” “You sat down on time this week.” These are what the course is actually trying to grow. Scores come and go; **the child who can sit down, ask for help, and adjust their own method goes the furthest.**

6)

6) Model it — and allow yourself to be the learner

If you would rather your child not use a phone at the dinner table, the most effective first move is to take your own phone off it. Conversely, now and then **let your child teach you something they have just learned** — how to annotate a screenshot, how to save a web page. This does two things at once: they revise, and the two of you build a little more mutual trust. In the digital world adults are not stronger than children at every point, and **admitting that is itself good parenting.**

7)

7) Watch for the unusual, and speak early

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If you notice a marked change — a cheerful child who suddenly goes quiet; a child who could never be pulled off the computer who now does not touch it for weekends on end; a child who always left their phone in the living room who now flatly refuses — do not rush to conclusions and do not rush to blame. **Ask gently first, then contact me promptly.** In my experience such changes often point to something specific that happened online. Concluding too quickly on too little information can deepen the wound.

8)

” ”

8) You can start the “family media agreement” conversation now

One Semester 2 module asks your child to draft a **family media agreement**, agree it with the family, live by it for a week, and then reflect. You can start that conversation now. A few opening questions:

- How much screen time does each of us have in a day — and how does a long stretch of it leave us feeling?
- What is appropriate to post, and what is not? What should we check before posting a photo?
- When we see something online that looks unreliable, what do we do about it?
- If someone online makes us uncomfortable, whom do we tell?

”“ ”“

Three practical notes: **write it in the positive** (“we will...”, rather than a long list of “don’ts”); **make it apply to every family member, parents included**; and **put it on the fridge, with an agreed date to revisit it**.

七、需要您知情的三件事

7. Three things you should know about

1. 3 1-2
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Your child will register accounts with an email address. A website-builder account in Week 3, plus one or two external course platforms during Semester 1. All free, email only, no phone number. **They will tell you before registering** — please take two minutes to look at which platform it is.

2.

AI

14

AI

AI-tool age terms. Some tools require guardian consent for users under 14. Nothing in Semester 1 requires an AI tool, and any child who cannot use one at home may ask to complete the relevant work on campus.
3.

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The site’s privacy settings and the year-end public option. The site is unindexed and pseudonymous by default, with no face photos or full school name. If at the end of Semester 2 your child wishes to make their portfolio public, **your written consent is required** — a separate note and consent form will reach you at that time.

Fill in whether a parent consent form exists, and its link or delivery method

八、我们的三个请求

8. Three things we ask of you

If only three things from this letter are worth remembering, these are they — plus one bonus:

1.

Protect two roughly one-hour slots each week. Put them in the family calendar and keep other tasks out of them.
2.

— —

Have one conversation a week about the three-line log — about the process, not an audit, and never about the score. Five minutes is enough.
3.

Do

not do their work, and do not write their emails. Sit with them, listen to them explain, be their first audience — but let the work and the email be theirs.
4.

“ ”

(Bonus) Be your child’s partner on registration and privacy. Glance at the platform before they sign up; after they publish, check the site together for a real name, a face photo, a full school name, and whether the no-index switch is on.

九、有问题找谁

9. Whom to contact

Who	What for	How
• Me — your child’s mentor	Weekly progress, work and feedback; technical trouble; falling behind; safety, privacy and accommodations.	Fill in the name and email address of the mentor sending this copy

Who	What for	How
Course site	Syllabus, weekly pages, rubrics, the semester calendar.	Fill in course site URL

24–48

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I reply to email **within 24–48 hours** (holidays excepted). If your child needs accommodations — for reading, writing, hearing, vision, attention, or anything else, such as extra time or an alternative format — please tell me early. We will find an arrangement that fits, and what you tell me stays confidential.

Fill in / whether a parent information session or 1:1 slots will be offered, in what form, and how to book

十、最后

10. In closing

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By the end of this year, I hope what you see is not only a website, a stack of artifacts, and two certificates. I hope you see **a child who can set their own goals, ask for help in their own words, find a way around what blocks them, and explain how they learned it.** Those capacities will not stay inside this course — they follow your child into every subject, every examination, and every unfamiliar field they will one day face alone.

And in all of that, **your part matters far more than you think — and asks far less of you than you fear:** not to be the teacher, not to be the supervisor, only to be the person who protects the time, listens properly, and holds back from taking over.

Thank you for your trust. I will see you along the way.

With warm regards,

Your child's mentor, Digital Learning

